

► RISING REEFS ►

In many parts of the tropics, ancient coral reefs have risen above sea level as plateaus of coral limestone. One of the largest of these areas is northern Yucatan in Mexico.

Here, there are no surface rivers, as the rainwater seeps down into a network of underground streams flowing through caves in the coral rock. At some places, the caves have collapsed to reveal beautiful pools called cenotes.



◀ DRY SEAS

During the last ice age, which ended some 10,000 years ago, world sea level fell by more than 400 ft (120 m), because so much water was frozen into huge ice sheets on land. This exposed the shallow continental shelves, and the continents became bigger. This map of North America shows the coastline as it was then, dotted red. Animals and people lived in areas that are now under water. Their remains are sometimes dredged up in fishing nets.



▲ GLACIAL REBOUND

World sea level rose after the ice age as meltwater flowed off the land. In places, however, the Earth's crust also started rising as it was relieved of the weight of the ice. This effect has raised ancient beaches well above the sea level, as in this bay in Wales.

